

The cellular phone market has a reason to rejoice. The demand for mobile phones have sky rocketed; business has kindled fierce competition between the service providers, and GSM service has become more affordable to the common man. Whether it is the affordability or the sheer joy of flaunting the sleekest models, the mobile phone craze has diffused through every section of our society. To take a close look at the booming handset market, we tested the best and latest instruments that are available in the Indian scenario. We covered five major brands and 35 models, and classified them into three categories: The 'Just a phone' category had the low-end, no-frills, affordable handsets; the 'Smart phone' category saw sets meant for the business user, that had a few extra features; the 'Also a phone' segment comprised gadgets that would, almost as an afterthought, also allow you to make a phone call.

How We Tested

Since a mobile phone is a consumer product, its allure is built through print advertisements and television commercials. This is why the looks and design of a model played integral part in its overall score—after all, everyone wants to buy a cute phone. Since mobile phones are also turning in to the smart devices that can perform tasks other than just making phone calls, we assigned maximum weightage to features.



The performance of the phones was tested by calling to and from landlines to the test handset from different locations such as open grounds and the innermost areas of a multi-storeyed building. We also noted down the period and type of warranty offered by the vendor and suitable weightage was assigned. The phones were categorised by the most determining factor—the price. All the phones that cost below Rs 8,000 were classified within the 'Just a phone' category. Similarly, the phones that fell within the price range of Rs 8,000 to Rs 18,000 formed the 'Smart phone' category; whereas all the phones above Rs 18,000 formed the 'Also a phone' category. The phones in the Just a phone category must possess features such as compact size, light weight, rugged body shell, decent address book capacity, and a standby battery life of around 2 days. They should also come bundled with some games, ring tones, a calculator, reminder options, etc. If the phone supported SMS chat, personalisation, had a calendar, or had WAP support, it earned extra points. Similarly, for the Smart phones we looked for features such as an address book with storage space of over 250, SMS storage capacity of at least 100, a good calendar to cram in reminders

or notes, capability to send notes and schedules via SMS, a larger screen to display long messages and the calendar, data connectivity through WAP or an IrDA port, and most importantly, a solid standby battery life of about a week. If a phone in this category had a colour display, an icon-based menu, GPRS or camera support, it edged ahead in terms of score.

	JUST A PHONE Price: Less than Rs 8,000 Page: 39
	SMART PHONE Price: Rs 8,000 to Rs 18,000 Page: 43
	ALSO A PHONE Price: More than Rs 18,000 Page: 52

Testing and benchmarking procedure

We evaluated the cell phones based on the following criteria: Style and design: We rated the look and feel of each and every phone on the scale of 5. We also took into consideration the opinions of mobile users.

The reason we rated style so highly, is the fact that even if a phone is very feature-rich and performs well, but looks average, there is very little chance of it being accepted by users. We looked at various features such as phone grip, build quality, keypad lock, shortcut customisation and so on.

The weightage assigned for the style and design to Just a phone was 20 per cent, Smart phone was 25 per cent and Also a phone was 35 per cent. Features: The features of the phones were logged and depending upon the categorisation, differing weightages were assigned. For example, SMS is ubiquitous and is a given in any cellular phone, be it low or a high-end. MMS however, is the in-thing and only present in the high-end pocket burners. We thus awarded points for MMS under the Smart phone and the Also a phone categories, whereas the phones in Just a phone were not evaluated on this particular feature.

We prepared a comprehensive feature list to pace the cellular phones through. Details such as ring tone functionality, group messaging, phone memory, display quality, ease of use, durability, grip, calendaring and to-do lists, PC connectivity, Bluetooth, IR, WAP and other Web browsing capability, HSCSD, GPRS, MP3 playback, etc, were all appropriately considered. Performance: Performance of a cell phone depends on the network. To avoid any ambiguity due to network loads, we tested the phones in three different network zones, at three different time intervals. Performance is a necessity, thus these scores did not vary across the three categories. Value for money: Value for money is an indicator of the overall price to performance ratio of a product. It is obtained by adding scores from performance and features, and factoring it with the price of a product. The weightage assigned to Just a Phone was 50 per cent, as price is the deciding factor in this category. For Smart Phones we assigned 25 per cent, and only 10 per cent for the Also a Phone category. Warranty and support: Warranty and support plays an important role for these costly, light, delicate and sensitive electronic devices. The requirement was a one-year warranty, and the option of a standby handset, in an emergency, is also a good option. However, we did not assign any weightage to it because all brands offered one year warranty.

Features table for cellphones
Find it on the Mindware CD
Some prices have changed after
CDs went to press

